Campus Santa Fe

Return-Game Design Document

Software Construction and Decision Making

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1. Game Design

1.1 Summary

Turn-based roguelike TCG game with a dark fantasy medieval aesthetic where you play as a fallen knight who is trying to get revenge for himself and his wife after an unfair exile. The progression system is based on boss fights, for which you get loot cards you can choose from to build your character from the ground up, upgrading your stats and affinities.

- Genre: Turn-based
- Differentiator: Use of cards to attack and power up your skills, and a parry system for better engagement during fights
- Ambientation: Medieval kingdom, Dark fantasy

1.2 Gameplay

Game Description

Return is a game that wants to enrich the experience of turn-based gamers by adding mechanics that make the game more active. The player plays as Edrick, an outlaw who was a knight once. As he is an outlaw, he only disposes of a sword and a shield at the beginning of the game.

The player starts the game in a forest that surrounds a castle at night, where he will find multiple signs explaining the game's mechanics. The mechanics that will be explained include how the TCG component works, how to parry an enemy, and how to move across stages.

After this, the player will go through different floors, where they will face randomly generated enemies that will change depending on the floor. After defeating a certain number of enemies, the player will be able to fight the boss of the floor and go to the next floor if they beat it. However, if the player is beaten by an enemy or boss, they will return to the forest at the start of the game and will have to repeat the process. Also, after beating an enemy, the player will receive experience, cards, and items, which will help them in the battles ahead. Throughout the game, the player will be able to change their equipment and raise their statistics through experience points when not battling.

While players complete the game some statistics will be saved in our database and analyzed. Some of the potential statistics that could be useful are:

- Average completion time: Mean time players took to finish the game.
- Progress: Current floor reached, and specific enemies/bosses defeated.
- Performance: Success rates of perfect vs. poor parries to track player mastery.
- Character data: Experience points, attribute levels, and the collection of permanent loot cards.

Game objective

The game's main objective is for the player to go through all the floors/stages to beat the final boss of the game, dominating the TCG and parry mechanics to achieve this. This implies perfecting these through the use of different strategies by trial and error.

Obstacles and challenges

The player starts with several items: a sword, shield, armour, and potions. Before each fight, the player can select up to 5 cards that they will use during the battle. Each turn, the player will select one card from their hand. Each card has different actions (attack, defend, spell, etc.). Each action will consume stamina points; the player will have to manage their stamina, which can be recovered through perfect parries. This is one of the main challenges of the game, as the player will have to learn to manage their stamina and master parries to recover it effectively.

Another challenge related to the TCG will be related with the roguelite element of the game. Because our game has roguelite mechanics, there has to be an element that the player can keep after each run of the game. In our game this element will be the cards you receive after each boss fight. The player can choose one of the cards after being defeated in a run, which will help them be stronger and stronger even after being defeated a lot of times.

Figure 1. Example of the card system and stamina point cost

Figure 2. Example of the health and stamina bars

Mastering parries will also be a challenge, as the parry will consist of a bar that the player must stop at the right moment. The indicator for the ideal parry will change positions each attack, while the size of the indicator will depend on the amount of stamina the player currently has. With these things in mind, the player must be paying attention to every moment of every fight, because even one single mistake while managing stamina or parrying can mean the end of a run.

Figure 3. Example of the parry bar

Throughout the three floors of the game, multiple enemies will be an obstacle to the player before getting to the final boss. Each one of the enemies on each floor will have a mechanic that will help the player prepare for the floor's final boss, which will also make enemies feel

unique. Each floor will have at least two to three enemies. Some enemies that could potentially appear are:

Enemy	Health	Physical damage	Magic damage	Special ability
Corrupted knight	150-320	15-30	0	Berserker rage: “A set of multiple attacks filled with rage.”
“Holy” spirit	200-420	0	18-35	Infection: “The spirit will infect the player and do damage over time.”
Shielded maiden	400-700	12-25	5-15	Iron Maiden: “The shield will open and will trap the player for one turn, dealing damage.”
Pale lancer	170-340	18-39	0	Impaling: “Low hit rate attack, which deals massive damage to the player”
Executioner	200-500	22-38	0	Mercy: “The executioner will give a hard, gentle cut that deals massive physical damage to the player.”

Table 1. List of potential enemies to include in the game

As mentioned before, the player will be able to reach the final boss after defeating a certain number of enemies. Some bosses that could potentially appear are:

Enemies	Health	Physical damage	Magic damage	Special abilities
Charles, the pale knight	400-600	20-40	20-40	Swift strike: “A set of multiple fast and elegant attacks” Corruption: “You can’t attack for two turns and will suffer damage over time”
Galahad of the hidden axe	550-800	38-50	0	Downfall: “A massive physical damage axe strike”
Gawain of the fair lance	900-1000	40-60	30-40	Piercing strike: “Pierces you physically and mentally, deals moderate physical and magic damage through two strikes, one of the physical lance and one of the spiritual lance”

Table 2. Potential bosses to appear in the game

1.3 Mindset

The game should generate satisfaction and excitement after defeating an enemy, as before each battle, there is a learning curve to master. The battles will be designed to be challenging from the beginning, but never unfairly difficult, to prevent people from quitting. Because of this, the player will feel proud after each battle and keep playing, exploring different

strategies and getting better at game mechanics like parries after each run. Additionally, the reward system will make the player feel like the battles are worth it by giving players experience, special loot and new cards depending on the stage.

The game will feature an engaging story of betrayal and revenge, designed to elicit sympathy for the main character. Furthermore, after each fight, brief flashbacks will be revealed, further enhancing the sense of excitement in the story. We want to make the player feel invested in the story and the characters to create the feeling of real stakes while fighting

1.4 Story

Brief of the story

The story will have a linear progression, where you will play as Edrick, a knight who has been betrayed by people who swore loyalty to him. He was once a respected knight in the kingdom, but was exiled because he was a suspect of killing the king's right hand. Because of this, he is now an outlaw who has to climb his way up through the castle and defeat enemies who were his allies once.

Our protagonist's past

Later in the story, the player will learn through flashbacks and the enemies' dialogues that the one who killed the king's right hand was actually his wife. She had been manipulating the people close to Edrick to provoke his exile.

Key elements that enrich our story

Music: The music will have a melancholic yet unsettling feeling, which will further affect the player's emotions during fights and flashbacks.

1.5 Illustrations

Figure 4. Main screen of the game with logo

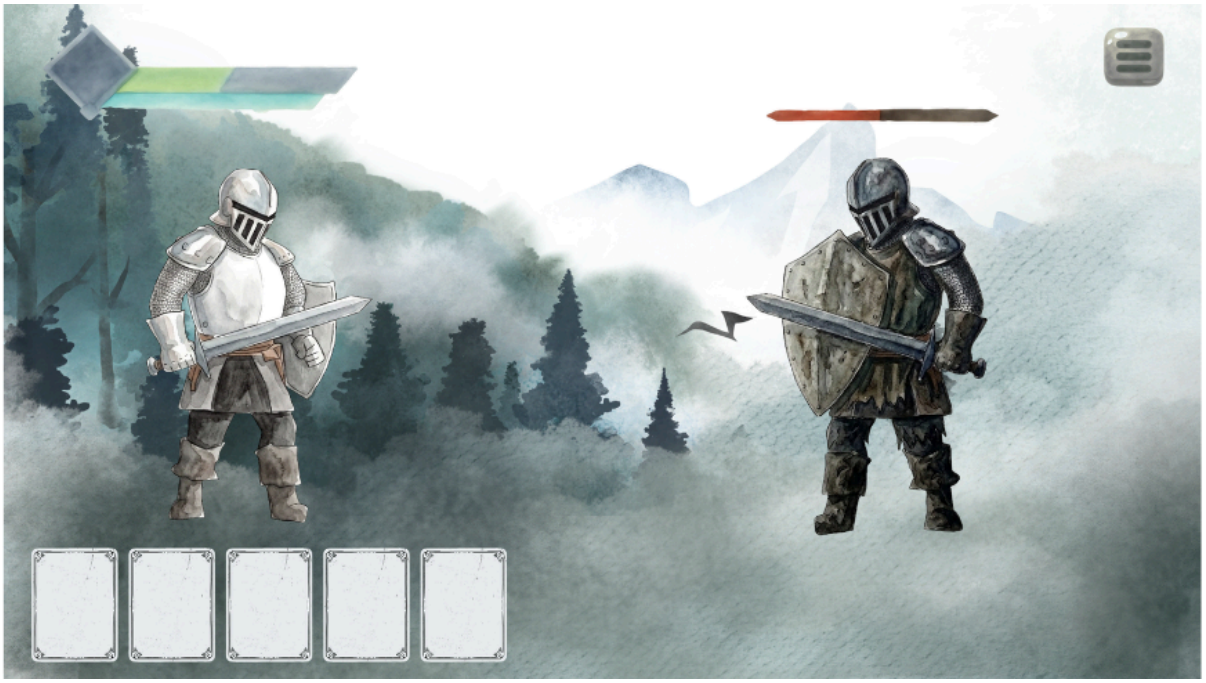

Figure 5. Main game scene

Figure 6. Game's main character

2. Technical

2.1 Screens

1. Loading Screen
2. Title Card screen
   2.1. Options
   2.2. Credits
3. Map Screen
4. Story Screen
5. Battle lobby Screen
6. Battle Screen

2.2 Controls

2.3 Mechanics

Parrying system

The parry system will work through a bar that will be available to the player in a certain time frame. The player will have to stop an indicator that will go through the bar. The bar will have subsections to indicate the kind of parry that will be executed after the indicator stops. The kind of parries available to the player will be:

- Poor parry: This type of parry will happen when the player stops the indicator in the red area of the bar or when they don't stop the indicator at all. When this kind of parry is executed, the player will lose large amounts of stamina and health.
- Normal parry: This type of parry will happen when the player stops the indicator at the yellow area of the bar. When this kind of parry is executed, the player will lose a small amount of health and gain a small amount of stamina.
- Perfect parry: This type of parry will be executed when the player stops the indicator at the green area of the bar. When this kind of parry is executed, the player will not lose any health and will gain a moderate amount of stamina.

Item Cards System

After each battle, enemies will drop loot in the form of item cards. These cards represent abilities, attacks, spells, or defensive actions that the player can use during combat.

When a card is obtained, it will be stored in the player's inventory, creating a collection of available cards that the player can choose from. However, before entering a battle, the player will only be allowed to select up to five cards from their inventory to form their active deck for that fight.

Each card will have specific characteristics such as:

- **Stamina cost**
- **Type of action** (attack, defense, spell, or support)

- **Damage or effect values**
- **Attribute requirements**

Cards may scale with the player's attributes, meaning that stronger attributes will improve the effectiveness of certain cards. For example, a physical attack card may deal more damage if the player has higher Strength, while magic-based cards may benefit from higher Intelligence.

This system encourages players to experiment with different card combinations and adapt their strategies depending on the enemies they face.

Attribute Progression System

After each battle, the player will receive experience points (XP) as a reward for defeating enemies. Accumulated experience will allow the player to level up, granting attribute points that can be distributed among different character attributes.

The attributes available to the player are:

- **Strength:** Increases the damage of physical attacks and weapon-based cards.
- **Vigor:** Increases the player's maximum health points.
- **Intelligence:** Improves the effectiveness and damage of magic-based cards.
- **Endurance:** Increases the player's stamina capacity and stamina regeneration.
- **Dexterity:** Improves combat efficiency, such as reducing stamina cost or improving certain card effects.

These attributes directly influence gameplay by modifying aspects such as:

- Maximum health points
- Maximum stamina points
- Damage dealt by attacks

- Effectiveness of cards
- Combat efficiency

This progression system allows players to customise their character build depending on their preferred playstyle.

Basic Combat Mechanics

- Combat in the game is turn-based, where the player and the enemy take turns performing actions. During the player's turn, they will select one card from the five cards chosen before the battle.
- Each card consumes a certain amount of stamina points, so players must carefully manage their stamina in order to avoid running out of resources during combat.
- Enemies will then execute their own actions during their turn, which may include physical attacks, magical attacks, or special abilities, depending on the enemy type.
- Because stamina can be recovered through successful parries, players are encouraged to balance offensive actions with defensive timing to survive longer battles.
- This system creates a gameplay loop where players must carefully manage their stamina, cards, and timing in order to defeat increasingly difficult enemies and bosses.

3. Level Design

4. Development

4.1 Abstract classes

4.2 Derived classes

5. Graphics

5.1 Style attributes

5.2 Graphics needed

6. Sounds/Music

6.1 Style attributes

First of all, our game has a dark fantasy medieval aesthetic and includes themes like vengeance, which is why the game's music must make the player feel tense and active. To achieve this, the game's music will focus on things like polyphonies and instrumentation that will make players feel like something is not right.

The music of the game will follow a similar style to games like Nier: Replicant and Elden Ring. These game soundtracks are characterized by having songs that make the environment feel tense and unsettling, but also exciting and thrilling. Through this kind of music, the player will feel excited and concentrated through the multiple battles across floors, which will generate better engagement with the game.

Soundtrack references:

- Nier: Replicant: https://open.spotify.com/intl-es/album/5EvfMZYvdWB2XPZT0IvcyI?si=LGRTYoQSQ--dkESyfskaog

- Elden Ring: https://open.spotify.com/intl-es/album/72oL3sD7toB7YvInNmrznf?si=zLNMxkinQnOkQPk-TU10rw

Now, if we talk about the sound effects of the game, we have to take into consideration that these must be concise. Most of the sound effects inside fights will consist of pieces of metal clashing to represent attacks and parries, while magic attacks and items will have effects depending on the effect or element. Outside of fights, sounds will consist of things like steps, collisions with walls, and dialogs. To avoid confusing the players, the sounds of things like parries and physical attacks will be different.

6.2 Sounds needed

Effects

1. Steps sound
2. Wall clash sound
3. Dialogue sound
4. Magic sound

Feedback

1. Healing
2. Hit (Damage to the player or to the enemy)
3. Sword clashing (For parries)
4. Experience gain

6.3 Music needed

1. Slow-melodic music with unsettling choir tones for the main menu
2. Slow- melodic music for the forest where the player starts
3. Fast paced unsettling music for fights against regular enemies (This one can change depending on the floor)

7. Schedule